DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Is Mazal, If Not the Stars?

Daat Tevunot §169-170

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §169-170 (section 9, part 3) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 23 October 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Page 564, §169. We learned that perfecting the world needs evil to intensify, but that this is only one way the tikkun comes about. The other is through increasing the light. Why some people are given the task of rectifying through suffering and others through receiving good is what the Ramhal calls mazal: in essence, a decree.

Two kinds of mazal

The Rabbi stressed not to confuse this with the mazal we learned about in Derech Hashem. There, mazal means "flow": how God's influence flows through the stars and planets. That is the meaning of "Ein mazal leYisrael". If you put yourself under it, you are influenced by it; but a Jew who lives with HaKadosh Barukh Hu directly can rise above it.

The mazal of section 9 is different. Call the first the lower mazal and this the upper mazal. It is the decree of whether I will serve Hashem through the intensifying of evil or through receiving light. That cannot be overridden.

§169: is it all luck, then?

The Neshamah says: if what you have told me is correct, then reward and punishment exist only in the next world, and here everything is luck. Everything that happens to us depends on mazal, not on our deeds.

§170: the famine in David's days

The Sekhel says this is incorrect, and first gives an introduction. The verse says there was a famine in the days of David. Hazal say it should have come in the days of Shaul, because of what was done to the Kohanim of Nov in his time. But the generation of Shaul could not withstand it, so God brought it in the days of David.

Hazal give a parable. The flax worker does not beat poor quality flax hard, because it will break. Good, strong flax he beats hard. God only strikes when we can withstand it.

The Ramhal draws the conclusion on page 566: God does not always use the system of mazal, only when He knows it is worthwhile. In Shaul's time it would not have been, because the

generation would not have survived it.

Two modes, and God chooses between them

God created deep orders in His running of the world. There are two ways:

1. **Reward and punishment**, the way of consequences.
2. **Mazal**, the way of decree.

They work together. God chooses when to use the one and when the other, according to what He knows is best for the world, and when He uses each, it runs according to its own laws.

Why the mixture makes the test real

The fact that there are two modes actually increases the merit of the righteous. If God used only mazal, a good person who suffers constantly could at least take comfort: I must be a saddik, because otherwise why would I be going through this? Anyone would choose such suffering, knowing it is the lot of the righteous.

But God wanted a real test, in which no one can understand what is happening to each person. As Kohelet says, the same thing happens to the righteous and the wicked. Some people suffer because of what they did, some because of mazal, and some because of both. You cannot know.

So you cannot sit back. This is why the Gemara says that if a person sees suffering coming upon him, he should examine his deeds. Nothing can be done about mazal, but reward and punishment is something you can affect. A participant added that one can always find something.

Another participant turned it around: if you have a great life, it may be that you are good and rewarded, or that your mazal is to be one through whom evil is intensified, by not suffering what you deserve. Or, as with Shaul's generation, you may be spared because you could not bear it. "You're right. It works both ways. We have no idea."

Solomon's observation

Hazal say in the Midrash that Shelomo looked through the generations and saw that what happens to the wicked happens to the righteous. The English note (35) gives examples: Avraham brought the world close to God and Nimrod rebelled against Him, yet both died; David prepared the site of the Mikdash and Nevukhadnessar destroyed it, yet both reigned forty years; Yoshiyahu was righteous and Ahav wicked, yet both were killed by arrows in battle. On the surface there is no difference between the fate of the righteous and the wicked.

Holding firm

All this strengthens the reward of the righteous: "the saddik lives by his faith." Since no one can judge whether something comes from reward and punishment or from mazal, a person's thoughts may race back and forth. A faithful person sets in his heart that every act of God is right and upright, and serves Him wholeheartedly whatever He sends. Then he is called wholesome.

That, said the Rabbi, is siduk hadin, the acceptance of divine justice we say at a funeral. Most of us just say it. The true saddik sees all the chaos and apparent randomness of the world and says: this is the will of Hashem.

Next time: how these two modes are not only used separately but together.

Summary

- The mazal of section 9 is not astrological influence, which a Jew can rise above, but the decree of how each person serves the tikkun.
- §170: like the famine delayed to David's time, God uses mazal only when the world can bear it.
- God runs the world by two modes, reward and punishment and mazal, and chooses between them as He sees best.
- Because both operate, no one can know why he suffers, so he must always examine his deeds.
- The faithful person accepts God's judgment wholeheartedly, which is the real meaning of siduk hadin.

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